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Indigenous Political Parties in Latin America

Introduction

A recent phenomenon across countries in Latin America is the emergence of Indigenous political parties. Indigenous peoples, historically an oppressed population of many Latin American countries, are starting to fully participate in the democratic systems of their respective countries. This has come about because of the Third Wave of Democracy that has swept over numerous Latin American countries. This Third Wave transformed the political environment of Latin America, and has established some sense of Democracy in most Latin American countries. The question I pose and hope to answer within my research paper is: How have the establishment of indigenous political parties and social movements in Latin America contributed towards the political environment of Latin America? In short, how do indigenous parties affect the democratic systems in their respective countries? In my research paper, I will delve into the positive and negative effects of indigenous parties in Latin America, and draw up my own conclusions on the topic.

My thesis is that ultimately, indigenous political parties are an overall positive to Latin American democratic institutions. To find if my hypothesis is right or not, I will delve deeper into the previously developed literature on the topic, as well as take an analytical look at countries that are currently affected by indigenous parties.

Because of the research I have already done, I came to the conclusion that Bolivia and Guatemala would be the best countries to analyze. Both countries have some sort of indigenous political organization and mobilization, with Bolivia having arguably the most successful indigenous political party in the region (MAS). While the indigenous parties in Guatemala are not as established, I feel it is important to analyze Guatemala because of the long history of indigenous social movements. It is also worthwhile to understand the different effects that indigenous parties and indigenous social movements produce. I expect indigenous parties in Bolivia to have a more positive effect on democracy in the country, due to the presence of an already established indigenous party in the country. Guatemala will be intrinsically different, due to the absence of indigenous parties on the same scale as Bolivia.

To support my thesis statement, I will also take into account the types of political institutions each respective country has had in the past, as that will take into account of how effective any political party will perform. (ex. history of Authoritarian rule, how recent Democracy has reached the country, level of Democratic consolidation). I will then use Raul Madrid's arguments for why indigenous political parties are a positive to democratic institutions and apply them to my three case study countries. His arguments are that: Indigenous parties help deepen democracy, reduce ethnic polarization, improve political representation, increase political participation, reduce party fragmentation, reduce electoral volatility in indigenous areas, increase the acceptance of democracy and reduce political violence. At the same time I will acknowledge the opposing arguments, and refute their claims.

Literature Review

Although indigenous political parties are a fairly recent phenomenon, there is already literature on the topic. Raul Madrid wrote an essay, *Indigenous Parties and Democracy in Latin America*, writing in favor of indigenous parties. He states that “the emergence of major indigenous parties in Latin America may actually help deepen democracy in the region.”(Madrid 161). Madrid touches upon 6 points that display the positives that indigenous political parties have brought to Latin America, while refuting critics of indigenous parties. Madrid argues that indigenous parties; improve political representation and participation, reduce electoral volatility and party system fragmentation, increase indigenous support for democracy and reduce political violence. He also offers 5 countries with emerging or already powerful indigenous political parties; Bolivia, Ecuador, Colombia, Nicaragua, and Venezuela. He chooses to focus mainly on Bolivia and Ecuador, who have the strongest indigenous political parties. Madrid uses empirical evidence to support his claims. When speaking on the matter of if indigenous parties in Bolivia increase voter turnout, Madrid states that “Between the 1997 and the 2002 elections, the number of votes cast rose by 35 percent in provinces that are majority indigenous...”(169). He also states that “Turnout, measure as a percentage of the voting age population, rose from 49.9 percent in 1997 to 55.5 percent in 2002 in majority indigenous provinces...”(169). His use of evidence helps him produce sound arguments.

Donna Lee Van Cott, author of *From Exclusion to Inclusion: Bolivia's 2002 Elections* explains how the indigenous parties of Bolivia captured a high percentage of the vote, as compared to previous elections. He attributes their surge to a number of interacting factors which include “institutional changes that opened the system”, “consolidation of indigenous

peoples' social movement organizations" and "...the intense anti-government mobilisations... in 2000" (Cott 751). In her essay, she finds that the mobilisation of indigenous parties and social movements brought about positive change in the democratic system of Bolivia. The ability for indigenous peoples to fully participate in Democracy and form parties are a big reason for their success in Bolivia.

Kanchan Chandra, author of *Ethnic Parties and Democratic Stability*, argues against the formation of indigenous political parties. She states that "Ethnic divisions, according to empirical democratic theory and commonsense understandings of politics threaten Democratic institutions." (Chandra 235), and that the threat that ethnic/indigenous parties pose is "insurmountable" (235). Contrary to Raul Madrid, Chandra argues that indigenous parties are a huge threat to Democracy, and in fact do not positively contribute to democratic systems. She ultimately concludes her essay by stating that indigenous parties are not necessary, and that around the world we have found that democratic systems that include indigenous parties are under threat to political violence. She believes this because indigenous parties can exacerbate ethnic divisions and conflicts.

Roderick Brett, author of *Social Movements, Indigenous Politics and Democratisation in Guatemala, 1985-1996* gives an expansive history of indigenous Guatemalan participation in politics. Before the indigenous parties of recent times, indigenous social movements in Guatemala emerged. Historically, indigenous peoples had little opportunity to participate in politics. Because of their exclusion, in 1973 a revolutionary, leftist guerrilla army was formed. The Comité Unidad de Campesino (CUC) came about in 1978, with a mission of "focusing on labour rights and the minimum salary" (Brett 59). With everything that social movements have

done to improve and secure indigenous participation and representation in Guatemala, the author argues that “the indigenous movement has not yet consolidated an irreversible foothold in Guatemalan society” (Brett 210). The changes that social movements have made thus far are not far reaching enough to affect everyday, poor indigenous Guatemalans.

Kevin Pallister, Author of *Why No Mayan Party? Indigenous Movements and National Politics in Guatemala* looks at why there is a lack of a strong indigenous political party in Guatemala. There are social movements instead of political parties, and political mobilisation of indigenous peoples happens at mainly the local level. The author argues that political repression and violence have hurt attempts at a national indigenous political party. As a result, indigenous Guatemalans win at a local level, but national elections main mostly non-indigenous. I felt that this was a good article to use because it is an example of a country with a sizeable indigenous population with an absence of national indigenous parties. This article can strengthen my argument, by showing the consequences of the absence of a national indigenous political party in a country with a big indigenous population.

Analysis

Bolivia:

From the beginning of the twentieth century, Bolivia had experienced “...an exclusionary and oligarchic multiparty system” (H/M 153). This is a similar case to other Latin American countries, who had also had an exclusionary system in place. The Bolivian revolution of 1952 brought about change to the political climate of Bolivia. Instead of an exclusionary oligarchic multiparty system, a hegemonic party system took its place. The MNR was the hegemon in this

case. The two other most relevant parties were the ADN and MIR. All three parties agreed on two key principles, "a representative democracy and a market economy" (H/M 154).

In 1964 there was a military coup, which ousted Victor Paz Estenssoro. This was the first of many military coups from 1964-1982, with 9 presidents in power from 1978-1982. 1982 marked the first year in which democratic elections would take place, and is thought of as the start of Bolivian democracy. The UDP, a center left party, gained power in 1982, but quickly lost it due to a severe economic crisis. New elections were called for in 1985, which brought the MNR back into power. Backed by the ADN, the MNR introduced the New Economic Policy, which brought about a radical transformation of the economy. This secured the future of Democracy in Bolivia, and had a "strong positive effect on the stability of the democratic regime" (H/M 152).

Even with the institutionalization of democracy in Bolivia and social reforms done by the National Revolution, the problems of lack of political representation and ethnic-cultural differences still persisted. This led to the establishment and rise of MAS and MIP. The MAS or Movement to Socialism was founded in 1995, and was created and lead by indigenous peoples. It had a platform of increasing the political representation of indigenous people in politics, as well as the nationalization of natural resources and social reforms. In 2006 Evo Morales, an indigenous Bolivian from MAS, won the presidency. This was the first time an indigenous Bolivian had taken the presidency in Modern Bolivian history. Bolivia is a "surprise" in Latin America during the third wave of democracy. Historically troubled by authoritarian governments and more recently military coup's, the stability of Bolivia's democracy is something political scientist did not expect.

From Exclusion to Inclusion: Bolivia's 2002 Elections goes more into depth on the conditions that lead to MAS victories. In 2002, MAS and MIP gained 27% of the national elections, which was a surprise even though the country is “62.05% indigenous” (Lee/Cott 752). Historically an underrepresented population in Bolivian politics, this was the first of many big victories that indigenous people experienced in government. Evo Morales of MAS finished second in the presidential elections as well. The Municipal decentralization of 1995 and the Laws of Popular Participation allowed for the creation of more political parties. By creating more municipalities in rural, indigenous areas, indigenous parties could capture more votes. The decline of the three main parties of the time, the MIR, MNR and ADN, the consolidation of indigenous parties into bigger parties, as well as anti government and anti- U.S. sentiment all paved way for MAS become a major party.

By applying Madrid's arguments to Bolivia, I will support my claims that indigenous political parties improve Democratic institutions. In Bolivia, ethnic divisions and polarization have not increased. In response to the rise of indigenous political parties lead traditional parties such as the MNR and MIR to “offer candidacies in 2002 to more indigenous and campesino leaders than ever before”(Lee/Cott 766). The emergence of indigenous parties made way for more ethnically diverse candidates in the traditional parties, who are historically non-indigenous. From their inception, indigenous parties in Bolivia have also included non-indigenous people, and have “...recruited nonindigenous as well as indigenous candidates for office...”(Madrid 165). Both traditional and Indigenous parties are getting more and more inclusive. Latin America is a continent where “ethnic identities in the region are characterized by a great deal of fluidity and ambiguity.”(Madrid 163). Bolivia is no exception, and most of the population is not solely one

ethnicity. The indigenous political parties in Bolivia have support from those who identify as part indigenous, as well as non-indigenous people.

Political representation has also been improved exponentially. By 2002, “approximately 85% of all MAS representatives in the legislature are indigenous.”(Marid 166). Also, by 2002, MAS held 35 seats in the legislature, up from none.(Madrid 156). This meant that MAS was the party with the second highest number of seats. The establishment of a strong indigenous party in Bolivia mobilized indigenous voters under one party, and finally allowed them a sizeable part of the legislature. This also ties into political participation. MAS is a political party intended to represent the needs of the indigenous population. This has attracted a large number of indigenous voters that had not voted before. In Bolivia,”Between the 1997 and the 2002 elections, the number of votes cast rose by 35 percent in provinces that are majority indigenous, as opposed to only 21 percent in provinces where indigenous people are in the minority.”(Madrid 169). While other factors are also at play (Laws of Popular Participation, Municipal Decentralization), indigenous political parties have done their part to convince indigenous people to vote. The empirical data shows that since the emergence of indigenous political parties, indigenous political participation and representation has only improved.

In order to understand how indigenous political parties in Bolivia have reduced party system fragmentation, it is important to understand which definition I chose to use. I will be using a definition given by Lauri Karvonen. She explains party system fragmentation as following: “A party system is fragmented if it contains more than two parties, none of which comes close to obtaining an absolute majority in the representative assembly.” By using this definition, it is apparent that since the emergence of indigenous political parties, party system

fragmentation has been reduced. Ever since the rise of MAS, the number of effective parties in majority indigenous provinces has gone down. From 1985-1997, there were an average of 4.6 effective parties. In 2002, that number was reduced to 4.(Madrid 170). Indigenous parties, and MAS especially, rally indigenous voters to their party. This consolidation of voters into one party means that other parties will lose voters, and therefore they become less relevant. This also ties into reducing electoral volatility; because indigenous voters have more or less been consolidated under MAS. In the past, indigenous majority provinces had a significantly higher percentage of electoral volatility (42%) compared to provinces where indigenous people were less than 1/3 of the population (24%). This could be because there was not one major party that all indigenous people thought best represented their interests. Now that MAS has entered the political field, electoral volatility should go down.

The emergence of indigenous political parties has given indigenous people a chance to be heard without the use of violence. Indigenous party leaders that show support for violent protests risk losing support from moderate indigenous voters as well as non-indigenous voters. The cost of using violence is too high for indigenous parties, as it threatens them losing their base of support. According to study done in Bolivia in 2002, “only one-third of indigenous respondents voiced support for roadblocks, and only 15 percent of them supported property invasions or takeovers of factories or buildings” (Seligson 2002,194–96).

Guatemala:

Guatemala has a history of authoritarian governments. This all changed in 1944, with the October revolution. Pro-democracy forces took control of the country until 1954.

In 1954, a military coup took power, supported by the CIA. This was in retaliation to the current president's waning support for the United Fruit Company. This culminated in the Guatemalan civil war which lasted from 1960-1996. On one side was the U.S. backed Guatemalan government, against leftist groups that included large populations of indigenous peoples. During this time period, there was a genocide against the indigenous people which took the lives of 200,000. Indigenous social movements in the country emerged to vocalize the issues that affected indigenous people. Throughout the 1980's there was a democratic transition, which saw the country shift from direct military rule to elected civil rule in 1986. This change was initiated by the then current government to "to guarantee institutional survival in a context of economic crisis and political pariah status in the international arena."(Brett 33). The peace agreement between the government and guerilla movements in 1994 put the country on a more stable path to Democracy.

Indigenous political mobilization in Guatemala is not a new phenomenon, with indigenous social movements being established in the 1960's and 1970's. Established in 1978, the Komite Unidad de Campesino (CUC) is regarded as the first popular indigenous movement. While it included both indigenous and non-indigenous participants, it had a "...principally indigenous leadership.."(Brett 59). Early social movements were targeted by the government in the 1970's, leading them to be wiped out or disband. Pan-Mayanist and Popular movements had begun to spread across Guatemala. Both movements were dependent of each other and both tackled issues that affected indigenous communities, especially human rights. Together, both movements make up the broader Guatemalan indigenous movement.

Guatemala is a country with approximately 40% indigenous population and 60% ladino population, with some sources stating that the indigenous population accounts for the majority.

(Brett 1). Ladino can include indigenous people who have shed their indigenous culture.

Historically, the indigenous population has also been disenfranchised and marginalized.

Guatemala is different from Bolivia in the sense that instead of strong national indigenous political parties, there is a Guatemalan indigenous movement. One cause of this may be because of the “stagnation” that democracy in Guatemala has faced. In *Guatemala: Democracy on Ice*” Mitchell Seligson identifies the major challenges in Guatemala’s democracy. These challenges are:

“1. The dilemma of peace accords that go too far, 2. The paradox of neoliberalism imposed upon a classic liberal economy, 3. The expansion of ethnic rights while intraethnic conflict increases, 4. The paradox of winning the war but losing the peace, and 5. The difficulty of building institutional democracy unsupported by a democratic political culture”(H/M 207).

By comparing Guatemala to Bolivia, I will be able to identify differences between countries with indigenous political parties and countries with only indigenous social movements.

The Guatemalan social movement has increased ethnic polarization. The civil war in Guatemala is a big factor in the ethnic polarization; the genocide that occurred had lead indigenous people to take on a “Mayan” ethnic identity. The Pan-Mayanist movement is a part of the Guatemalan indigenous movement, which means that ethnic identity is a focal point of the movement.

Political representation has not increased much as well. As of 2000, “Only 11% of legislators...were indigenous”. The lack of political representation could have a number of reasons. Because of the lack of one national indigenous party, such as MAS in Bolivia, there isn’t a force that can consolidate indigenous people to vote for one party. Another reason could

be that the indigenous movement has not done as good of a job mobilizing indigenous people to directly participate in politics at a national level. This ties directly into political participation, with indigenous political participation characterized as “individual participation in ladino-dominated parties and short-lived efforts at creating parties around prominent indigenous leaders.”(Pallister 120) At the same time, the major parties have not addressed the issues that face the indigenous community, discouraging indigenous people from voting at all. Indigenous candidates that run under one of the major parties have tended to not act as a representative of the indigenous movement, more specifically the Mayan movement.

The current state of the party system of Guatemala can be described as “highly fragmented, fluid, and marked by low levels of party attachment in the electorate”(Pallister 122). The party system is highly fragmented, and has a high level of electoral volatility. Whereas MAS in Bolivia had mobilized people on a national level, the indigenous movement in Guatemala has mobilized people on a local level. Even though the indigenous people in Guatemala largely identify as “Mayan”, there are still differences between the indigenous groups in Guatemala. Divisions in the Indigenous movement have also curtailed unity on the level that MAS has achieved. In place of indigenous parties, civic committees have emerged. These are small groups of citizens that field candidates for municipal elections, and they have been largely successful. The indigenous leaders have preferred civic committees to political parties, as some view the use of indigenous candidates by major parties as “decorative figures”(Pallister 127) However, the strength of civic committees can contribute to the weakness of indigenous parties. By reinforcing local participation, they discourage national unification.

It is hard to say if the Guatemalan indigenous movement has increased or decreased political violence. The legacy of the genocide as well as current violence against indigenous Guatemalans seeking political office tells me that the government and other non-state actors are the source of political violence. The lack of unity between the indigenous people at a national level (other than identifying as Maya) leads me to believe that coordinated political violence against the state and non-indigenous people is not as big of an issue.

The indigenous movement has taken steps to deepen democracy in Guatemala, however solely at a local level. Civic committees give indigenous people political voice, and there have been attempts at creating a strong national indigenous political party. However, the successful creation of a national indigenous party would deepen democracy even further. As it stands, there is little indigenous representation at a national level, something the indigenous movement must fix.

The Problem of Ethnic Outbidding:

Kanchan Chandra has spoken out against ethnic based parties, stating that they “threaten the survival of democratic institutions”(235 Chandra). She points to the phenomenon known as “ethnic outbidding”. This is a theory that states that politicizing ethnic divisions through the means of a political party will lead to the rise of more and more ethnic based parties, and will destabilize democracy. She looks to the effects that ethnic parties and ethnic outbidding had on India. The first election in post-colonial India included 4 ethnic parties, 3 of which sought support of the Hindu majority and 1 which sought support from ex-untouchables in the caste system. In an attempt to gain the most Hindu voters, 1 party adopted an “extreme position” by “attempting to pit Hindus against Muslims”(Chandra 238). Two parties tried to pit the lower

castes against the higher castes. However, she states that ethnic parties in India ended up adopting more centrist platforms later down the line. This had to do with the fact that no one group constituted a majority in India, and ethnic parties had to consolidate in order to gain power.

Throughout my research of ethnic parties in Latin America however, I have not found any significant cases of ethnic outbidding. India has key differences from Latin America that causes ethnic-based parties to have different effects in each respective region. India has a plurality of ethnic divisions, to the point that it cannot be compared to a single Latin American country. In Latin America indigenous peoples more or less have banded together to form inclusive parties, as opposed to India where the effects of the caste system, language, religion, region, and many more continue to divide people into small groups. In Latin America indigenous parties have time and time again consolidated, which is evident with the rise of MAS. Latin America is a place where ethnicity is fluid, allowing one person to identify with a number of ethnic groups. Chandra even addresses this, stating that “Theories of ethnic outbidding assume that ethnic identities are intrinsically fixed. Such fixity, their proponents claim, generally leads to destabilizing party behavior.”(Chandra 245). In a region with ethnic fluidity such as Latin America, ethnic outbidding is not as apparent.

In Latin America, the rise of indigenous parties was in response to; the legal entry of indigenous persons into the democratic process and the failure of already established major parties to tackle issues that indigenous people face. Throughout my research, I have not found “White” or non-indigenous parties rising and gaining power. While it can be argued that the already established major parties are in fact white or non-indigenous parties, both major parties

and indigenous parties are made up of different ethnicities. Indigenous parties have sizeable non-indigenous participation. Evo Morales's vice president appears to be a non-indigenous person, but has still been able to ascend the party leadership. Major parties in Guatemala have fielded indigenous leaders in an attempt to gain indigenous voters.

Indian ethnic parties can exacerbate ethnic divisions and political violence through ethnic outbidding. However, extremist indigenous parties in Latin American countries fail to gain sizeable support. In the case of Bolivia, indigenous parties that have an extremist platform lose support from moderate indigenous people as well as non-indigenous people.

Chandra's explanation of the Theory of Ethnic Outbidding is flawed; while stating that ethnic parties pose a major threat to democracy, she goes on to state that eventually the ethnic parties adopt centrist platforms in order to consolidate ethnicities. If ethnic outbidding does occur, the problem will solve itself. Countries in Latin America discredit the theory, at least on a global scale.

Conclusion

Bolivia is just one example of how indigenous political parties positively affect Democracy. Ecuador, Colombia as well as Venezuela have experienced a rise in indigenous political parties as well. With Bolivia producing MAS, arguably the best example of an indigenous party in the region, we have seen that political participation and representation has increased as well as support for democracy, ethnic polarizations are on the decline, and party system fragmentation and electoral volatility have been reduced.

Comparing Bolivia to Guatemala, I would conclude that Guatemala is in need of a strong national indigenous party. The establishment of an Indigenous movement is not enough to bring

about positive change for Democracy in a respective country. Guatemala is an example of what can happen when a country with a sizeable indigenous population fails to establish a political party. Guatemala also serves as a reminder to how much strong indigenous political parties positively affect democracy, by showing us what happens in a country with a sizeable indigenous population that fails to produce an indigenous party.

Compared to indigenous social movements, indigenous political parties can; increase political representation and participation at a national level, reduce political violence, electoral volatility, and party system fragmentation. While both indigenous social movements and indigenous political parties can deepen democracy, indigenous political parties like MAS have taken it a step further. Indigenous parties like MAS have managed to make the political system much more inclusive at both local and national levels, and have the ability to do what indigenous social movements cannot, due to better structural organization and unity. However, the recent history of indigenous people in Guatemala leaves me to believe that there are major factors inhibiting a successful national indigenous political party. The recent history of genocide, coupled with the weakness of political parties in general signify why a successful indigenous party has not occurred yet. Once democracy in Guatemala is more consolidated, I believe that an effective indigenous party similar to MAS will develop.

Ethnic outbidding can cause problems in democratic institutions, but that is not the case in Latin American countries. The history and fluidity surrounding ethnicity in Latin America has produced a different experience with ethnic-based parties compared to other regions around the world. To say that all ethnic parties cause ethnic outbidding would be untrue.

While the historical experiences of indigenous people across Latin America may not be uniform, I still support my thesis. The trend of indigenous people politically mobilizing to form indigenous parties has already created positive effects on the region. Indigenous parties in Latin America act as a machine; their purpose is to mobilize indigenous people, and gain political representation of a group of people that have been excluded from the political process. In the future, I believe that indigenous parties will fade away. The indigenous parties are already ethnically inclusive, and will either lose their indigenous label or lose support to major non-indigenous parties, who also show signs of inclusiveness. Indigenous political parties are a stepping stone towards a more ethnically inclusive democracy in Latin America.